

SPHESIHLE INNOCENT MLANZI

Full-Stack Developer · AI-Native

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[LinkedIn](#) · [GitHub](#) · [Portfolio](#)

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Full-Stack Developer with hands-on experience in shipping production features across TypeScript, React, Next.js, Node.js, and PostgreSQL. I build end-to-end, owning features from data model and API design through to UI implementation and deployment. Daily user of Claude Code and Cursor as core development tools, not add-ons. Built UniConnect solo, a full-stack AI-powered platform with an LLM document extraction pipeline, Flutter mobile app, and CI/CD, from scratch, without handoffs. Background in design that translates into sharp UI/UX instincts. Excited by hard problems, fast-moving teams, and AI-native products used at scale.

AI-NATIVE DEVELOPMENT — HOW I WORK

AI is not a tool I use occasionally — it is central to how I build. Here is what that looks like in practice:

- **Daily Claude Code usage:** writing boilerplate, exploring unfamiliar APIs, debugging edge cases, and refactoring for readability — treating it as a collaborative thinking partner, not a code generator to paste blindly.
- **Prompt engineering discipline:** I write precise, context-rich prompts and validate all AI-generated code against expected behaviour before committing. I understand where LLMs hallucinate and where they shine.
- **AI-assisted prototyping:** I use Claude Code to compress the distance between idea and working prototype — then iterate based on real feedback, not assumptions.
- **Automated testing support:** I use AI tools to scaffold unit and integration tests, improving coverage without slowing delivery.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Full-Stack Developer · Culture Creative

November 2023 – Present

Shipping production features end-to-end across CareerDash and BrainBox AI — live platforms with active users — owning the full stack from React frontends to Node.js APIs and PostgreSQL in a lean, agile team.

- **Owned and shipped production** improvements across CareerDash and BrainBox AI — working end-to-end across React frontends, Node.js REST APIs, and PostgreSQL data workflows in an agile, remote-first team.
- **Integrated Claude Code and Cursor** into daily development workflow — using AI assistance for debugging, refactoring, test generation, and code review, significantly reducing time-to-ship per feature.
- **Built and maintained REST API** endpoints and data pipeline logic including input validation, error handling, and structured data extraction from third-party integrations.
- **Collaborated closely with a senior engineer** on architecture decisions, code reviews, and sprint planning — taking direction while owning assigned tasks end-to-end.
- **Maintained REST API integrations** with third-party services, handling authentication, error states, webhooks, and data transformation between systems.
- **Identified product and operational bottlenecks** through analysis of real user behaviour, then proposed and delivered practical solutions that reduced friction and improved user outcomes.

Graphic Designer & 3D Artist · Pestro Projects

March 2022 – April 2023

- **Produced high-quality 2D and 3D** visual assets for branding, marketing, and digital campaigns across multiple concurrent client projects.
- Transitioned into software engineering mid-2023 through intensive self-directed training in full-stack development (React, Node.js, TypeScript) and AI engineering fundamentals.

FEATURED PROJECT

UniConnect — AI-Powered University Application Platform · [Personal Build](#) 2025 – Present

A full-stack platform replacing manual, error-prone university application processes for South African students with structured, AI-assisted automation.

- **Built with Claude Code throughout:** used AI assistance to scaffold the data model, generate and refine API endpoints, write validation logic, and produce test coverage — iterating rapidly from prototype to working product.
- **PostgreSQL backend:** designed relational schema for multi-step application workflows, validation logic, and real-time progress tracking.
- **REST API layer:** built structured endpoints handling form submission, document extraction, and status updates — consumed by a Flutter frontend.
- **AI feature integration:** implemented document extraction and data standardisation using LLM-assisted processing, with human-readable outputs users can trust and verify.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: TypeScript, JavaScript, Dart, Python actively learning

Backend: Node.js, REST APIs

Frontend: React, Next.js, Flutter, HTML5, CSS3

Databases: PostgreSQL (Schema Design, Relational Modelling), Supabase, Firebase

AI Workflow: Claude Code (daily), Prompt Engineering, Automated Data Extraction

DevOps: Git, GitHub (branching, PRs, code review), Docker, CI/CD Pipelines, Vercel, AWS Fundamentals

Integrations: REST APIs, Webhooks

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

Bachelor of Commerce — Accounting · [University of Johannesburg \(incomplete\)](#) 2019 – 2021

National Senior Certificate · [Sakhelwe High School](#) 2010 – 2016

Certifications:

- **Become an AI Engineer** — LinkedIn Learning
- **Docker Foundations Professional Certificate** — Docker & LinkedIn
- **Career Essentials in GitHub** — GitHub & LinkedIn
- **Microsoft Azure AI Essentials** — Microsoft & LinkedIn

Languages: English · isiZulu